

Impact: High Difficulty: Easy-Medium Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

What you need -> By when -> Why it matters -> One ask — stop

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before making any request, answer: what specifically do I need, and by when? State those two things. Leave out the rest.

BEST FOR

- Delegating tasks clearly
- Asking colleagues for help without ambiguity
- Setting expectations in professional relationships
- Reducing back-and-forth caused by unclear requests

PHRASE BANK

Clean Request Core · What, when, why

- "I need X from you by Thursday at 5 pm."
- "Could you do X? I need it before the 3 pm call."
- "One specific thing: I need you to..."
- "I have a simple request — can you...?"
- "The ask is: please send me X by end of day."
- "I need your input on one thing before tomorrow."
- "Can you confirm you have received this and flag any blockers?"
- "The deliverable I need from you is X."

Request Follow-Up · Confirming and clarifying

- "Does that feel doable by then?"
- "Any blockers I should know about?"
- "Let me know if the scope is unclear."
- "Flag me if that timeline does not work."
- "Does anything in that ask need clarification?"
- "I want to make sure that lands clearly — any questions?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Vague: 'Could you look at this at some point?'
Better: Can you review this when you get a chance?
Best: Can you review section 3 and send your notes by Thursday noon?
2. Weak: Over-explaining before making the ask
Better: I have a project that needs input — can you help?
Best: 'I need your input on X by [date]. Context: one sentence.' Then stop.
3. Weak: Multiple bundled requests in one message
Better: I have a few things — can we go through them?
Best: One clean request. Then a second message for the next one.

DECISION TREE

If You have a vague request in mind

Answer: what specifically? By when? Then make the request.

"I need X completed by Y. Let me know if anything is unclear."

If The other person does not know why the task matters

Add one sentence on the stakes.

"This feeds into the board meeting, so I need it by Wednesday."

If You are making multiple requests at once

Make the most important one. Do not bundle.

"One thing for now — can you do X? I will follow up with the rest."

If The request was not done to spec

Clarify what was missing rather than blame.

"I should have been clearer — what I actually needed was..."

If Someone asks a vague favour

Ask: what specifically and when?

"Happy to help — what do you need and when?"

SCENARIOS

Delegating a task to a team member

What, by when, what good looks like. — "Can you have the first draft of X ready by Friday at noon? Three pages max."

Asking a busy senior person for something

Crisp ask up front, one line of context. — "I need five minutes of your time before the 3 pm call to get your sign-off on the approach."

Following up because a task was not done

Restate the request clearly rather than criticising. — "I wanted to follow up on X — could you get that to me today?"

Asking for help from a peer

Specific ask with a respectful timeline. — "Could you look over this proposal and flag any gaps? I need it back by Wednesday."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the relationship is such that a formal request would feel clinical or cold.
- In brainstorming contexts where you want open-ended input rather than a specific deliverable.
- When you genuinely do not know what you need — clarify that first, then make the request.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Audit your requests

Review one request you made today. Was it specific? Did it include a deadline? Could it be cleaner?

Day 2 — What and when

For every request you make today, include both what you need and by when.

Day 3 — One ask at a time

Send your requests as separate messages rather than bundled. Notice if clarity improves.

Day 4 — The why in one line

Add one line of context to an important request. Just one line.

Day 5 — Confirm understanding

After making a request, ask: 'Anything unclear?' once. Not repeatedly.

Day 6 — Written requests

Rewrite one email request to strip it down: ask first, context second, no filler.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your requests land better this week? Were there fewer follow-up questions or missed deadlines?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I state the request specifically — not vaguely?
- Did I include a clear deadline or timeline?
- Did I make one request, not several bundled together?
- Did I add context only where genuinely needed?
- Did I confirm understanding without nagging?
- Was the request clear enough that the person did not have to guess what I meant?
- Did I avoid making the request sound like a demand or an instruction?